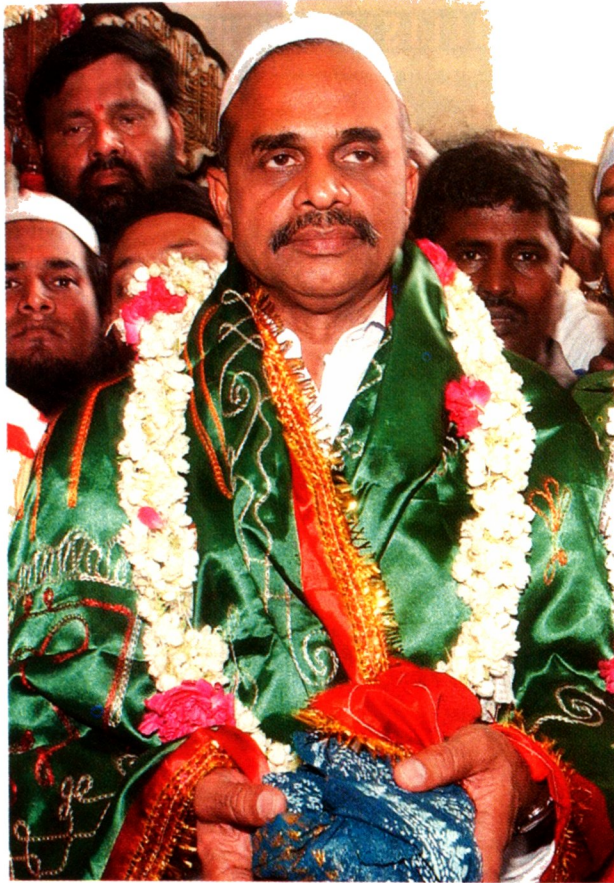


**P**oliticians have always had the tendency to pandering to religious minorities. They all swear by secularism but Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y. S. Rajasekhara Reddy has turned it into a science. Eager to dole out sops in a bid to perpetuate his hold on power, his Government has now decided to provide subsidy for Christians going on pilgrimage to the Holy Land in Israel, similar to the Haj scheme for Muslims. Not long ago, he had launched a scheme for conducting mass marriages for poor Hindus. This will be extended to Muslims and Christians from April this year, exactly a year ahead of the Lok Sabha and Assembly polls in the state.

The roots of the current decision spring from a Christmas gathering at which Reddy, a Christian, met Archbishop of Hyderabad Marampudi Joji. The archbishop requested Reddy to assist Christians in fulfilling their wish of making a pilgrimage to the Holy Land by offering a travel subsidy. There are about 1.2 million Christians in the state who represent nearly 2 per cent of the eight crore population of Andhra Pradesh.

The decision seems to have opened a can of worms and demands for similar doles are being raised by different communities. "Why does the Government not provide a subsidy to pilgrims visiting Vaishno Devi temple or Kailash Mansarovar," says G. Kishan Reddy, leader of BJP in the Legislative Assembly.

In fact, the validity of the Haj subsidy is now being challenged in the courts as being unconstitutional. One of the grounds of challenge is that it aids people of a specific religion and thereby interferes in the matter of the state's allo-



## Discount on RELIGION

**With an eye on the polls next year, the chief minister goes out of his way to woo minorities**

cation of its financial resources. Last year, about 1,57,000 Indian Muslims performed Haj with the Centre ensuring hassle-free pilgrimage, pulling Air India flights out of normal schedule to fly pilgrims to the holy cities of Mecca and Madina in Saudi Arabia. In Andhra Pradesh, there is an exclusive Haj house and the government extends all facilities from vaccination to issuing of boarding passes to Haj pilgrims under one roof.



K BHASKAR

Interestingly, Saudi Arabia frowns on Haj subsidies on the grounds that it goes against the spirit of

**POPULISM: Reddy, himself a Christian, has agreed to Joji's (below) appeal**

the Shariat. Islamic clerics point out that Haj is a religious duty only for those who can afford it and the pilgrimage may not be "accepted by God" if expenditure on transport and on food is not the pilgrim's own. Even Pakistan discontinued Haj subsidy after the Lahore High Court ruled that any expense defrayed by the government for the Haj was contrary to the Shariat.

A little known fact is that a subsidy is offered to Hindus for their pilgrimage to Kailash Mansarovar. While the Ministry of External Affairs routes the subsidy for each pilgrim through the Kumaon Mandal Vikas Nigam, the Uttar Pradesh Government also gives a dole to every pilgrim. Both Delhi and Gujarat governments offer doles to those who are domiciles or belong to the two states.

Since becoming the chief minister in 2004, Reddy has aggressively wooed Muslims, who comprise about 9 per cent of the state's population. He was the first to attempt to provide reservations in jobs and seats in educational institutions to Muslims. After the courts struck down his plan to provide 5 per cent reservation, the state came up with a new idea if giving the community 4 per cent reservation in jobs. A larger bench of the Andhra Pradesh High Court is examining the issue.

For the chief minister—who had gone on a thanksgiving trip to Bethlehem, barely seven months after he assumed office—it seems to be an unwise move. If the high court strikes it down, it will be an embarrassment for his Government. If the court upholds the decision, similar demands from Christians cannot be ruled out. Either way, Reddy will be mortified to discover that populism is a hot potato that could scald his hands.

**by Amarnath K. Menon**